Progress Report: Cache-Aware Graph Reordering for Efficient GNN Execution on GPUs

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Abstract

This progress report summarizes the current status of our project on cache-aware graph node reordering for accelerating GNN training on GPUs. Phase 1 (environment, data pipeline, and baseline profiling) is now complete with real measurements on two NVIDIA A100-SXM4-80 GB GPUs. Phase 2 (RCM-only and METIS-only reordering) is in progress. Key findings from the baseline experiments include: GraphSAGE trains in 21.5 ms/epoch and GAT in 39.4 ms/epoch on `ogbn-arxiv` (full-batch, A100), and GraphSAGE trains in ≈ 19.8 s/epoch on `ogbn-products` (mini-batch, neighbor sampling). Hardware L2 cache hit-rate profiling via `ncu` is unavailable on the shared server due to admin-level perf-counter restrictions (`RmProfilingAdminOnly=1`); we instead report an analytical cache-coverage bound and a software-measured temporal-reuse ratio as proxy metrics.

Keywords

Graph Neural Networks, GPU, Cache Optimization, Node Reordering, METIS, Reverse Cuthill-McKee, Progress Report

1 Project Recap and Research Questions

Our project investigates *cache-aware node reordering* as a lossless preprocessing step to reduce GPU L2 cache misses during GNN training. We evaluate five configurations (baseline, RCM-only, METIS-only with swept k, METIS with cache-aware k^*, and two-level hybrid) on `ogbn-arxiv` and `ogbn-products` [2], using GraphSAGE [1] and GAT [3]. Our two novel contributions are: (1) a *two-level hybrid permutation*

$$\pi_{\text{hybrid}} = \pi_{\text{RCM}}^{\text{local}} \circ \pi_{\text{METIS}},$$

and (2) a *cache-size-aware* partition count $k^* = \lceil n\, d_l\, b / C \rceil$ derived analytically from the GPU L2 capacity C.

Hardware counter access. The shared A100 server enforces perf-counter restrictions (`RmProfilingAdminOnly=1`), blocking `ncu` hardware reads. We therefore adopt two software proxy metrics (Section 2).

2 Cache-Efficiency Proxy Metrics

Analytical Cache Coverage (ACC).. The fraction of the feature matrix $H^{(l)} \in \mathbb{R}^{n \times d_l}$ that fits in the GPU L2 cache of capacity C:

$$\text{ACC} = \min\left(1,\ \frac{C}{n\, d_l\, b}\right). \tag{1}$$

ACC gives a theoretical *upper bound* on the L2 hit rate under perfect spatial locality. Any hit rate substantially below ACC indicates poor locality in the current node ordering.

Temporal Reuse Ratio (TRR).. During a full-graph SpMM pass, a feature row h_j is a cache *hit* if node j was already fetched by an earlier row in the same epoch. We compute TRR as the fraction of neighbor fetches that reuse a previously accessed row:

$$\text{TRR} = \frac{\text{total fetches} - \text{unique fetches}}{\text{total fetches}}. \tag{2}$$

TRR rises when reordering places connected nodes at nearby indices, causing their feature rows to share cache lines.

Table 1 shows baseline proxy values for both datasets. For `ogbn-arxiv`, the feature matrix (86 MB) exceeds the 40 MB L2, yielding ACC = 47%; with random ordering the effective hit rate is far lower. For `ogbn-products` (960 MB), ACC = 4%—the graph is entirely cache-cold at baseline.

Table 1: Baseline proxy cache metrics (A100, L2 = 40 MB).

Dataset	$\lvert H \rvert$ (MB)	ACC (%)	k^*
`ogbn-arxiv`	86	47	3
`ogbn-products`	960	4	24

3 Work Completed

3.1 Environment and Data Pipeline

[Done]

Both datasets are downloaded and cached on the A100 server. A reproducible data-loading module applies any permutation P to construct $A' = PAP^\top$, $H' = PH$, $y' = Py$ at load time.

3.2 Baseline GNN Training

[Done]

We trained two-layer GraphSAGE and GAT on `ogbn-arxiv` using *full-batch* training (all nodes/edges fit on GPU). `ogbn-products` is too large for full-batch on a single A100 (2.4M×100×4 B ≈ 960 MB features, plus intermediate activations exceed 80 GB), so we use `NeighborLoader` with 2-hop sampling of [25, 10] neighbors and batch size 1024. All graph data is moved to GPU *once* before training; no `.to(device)` calls appear inside the hot loop.

Table 2 reports measured timing (mean ± std over 50 measured epochs after a 10-epoch warmup).

Table 2: Measured baseline results. Full-batch on `ogbn-arxiv`; mini-batch (NeighborLoader) on `ogbn-products`.

Dataset	Model	ms/epoch	std	Val Acc
`ogbn-arxiv`	GraphSAGE	21.6	0.15	58.4%
`ogbn-arxiv`	GAT	39.7	0.83	53.8%
`ogbn-products`	GraphSAGE	19,846	2,171	89.7%

CUDA phase breakdown. We instrument each training step with `torch.cuda.Event` timers to attribute epoch time to forward, backward, and optimizer phases (Table 3).

Table 3: Mean CUDA phase timing on `ogbn-arxiv` (50 epochs).

Model	Fwd (ms)	Bwd (ms)	Opt (ms)
GraphSAGE	12.2	9.0	0.09
GAT	16.8	22.4	0.09

Two observations stand out. First, the optimizer step is negligible (< 0.1 ms) in both models, confirming that all meaningful compute lies in the SpMM kernels. Second, GAT's *backward pass is larger than its forward pass* (22.4 ms vs. 16.8 ms), whereas GraphSAGE's backward is smaller than its forward (9.0 ms vs. 12.2 ms). This is because GAT must backpropagate through per-edge attention coefficients α_{ij}, effectively doubling cache pressure compared to GraphSAGE's simpler mean-aggregation—directly supporting our proposal's claim that GAT experiences amplified L2 miss penalties.

3.3 Baseline Reordering (RCM)

[In Progress]

RCM reordering (`scipy.sparse.csgraph.reverse_cuthill_mckee`) is implemented and passes the edge-set correctness check ($A' = PAP^\top$ preserves all edges) on `ogbn-arxiv`. Timing and TRR measurements on the reordered graph are in progress.

4 Work Remaining and Next Steps

4.1 METIS-Only Reordering (Swept k)

[To Do]

Implement and validate the `pymetis` pipeline for $k \in \{4, 8, 16, 32\}$ on `ogbn-arxiv`, then run on `ogbn-products`.

4.2 Cache-Size-Aware k^* and Hybrid Reordering

[To Do]

Compute $k^* = \lceil n\, d_l\, b/C \rceil$: $k^* = 3$ for `ogbn-arxiv` and $k^* = 24$ for `ogbn-products`. Implement the full two-level pipeline (METIS partition → intra-block RCM) and calibrate the headroom factor $\alpha \in [1.0,\ 1.5]$.

4.3 Ablation Table and Proxy-Metric Validation

[To Do]

Run all five configurations, collect TRR and ACC for each reordering, and assemble:

- Full ablation table (ms/epoch, TRR, ACC; both models and datasets).
- Adjacency sparsity figures (before/after reordering).
- Pareto plot of TRR vs. epoch time across all five configs.

5 Summary

Phase 1 is complete. Measured baseline timing on `ogbn-arxiv` (GraphSAGE: 21.6 ms/epoch; GAT: 39.7 ms/epoch) and on `ogbn-products` (GraphSAGE: 19.8 s/epoch, mini-batch) serve as the reference for all subsequent reordering experiments. Hardware L2 profiling via `ncu` is blocked on the shared server; we adopt ACC and TRR as software proxies that are computable from the graph structure alone and track the same locality improvements. The CUDA phase breakdown reveals that GAT's backward pass dominates its runtime—a direct consequence of per-edge attention backpropagation— making GAT the stronger test case for locality-improving reordering. Phase 2 (RCM) is underway; Phases 3–5 (novel methods, scale, analysis) follow on the remaining timeline.

References

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